subcontinent in the early sixteenth century, by the mid-nineteenth century, the Europeans had ensconced themselves throughout the Indo-Pacific, reaching into Chinese territory, yet hardly into the Pacific Ocean itself.[6]

When the Americans came in the late eighteenth century, they initially followed the familiar European route but soon shifted to the far more daunting Pacific route, approaching from the east across the vast ocean, thus opening up an entirely new set of sea routes.[7] American trading ships traversed thousands of miles of barely known maritime territory, stopping at small, widely separated island chains before suddenly arriving in Asia proper, congested with empires and kingdoms, and dotted with European colonial fortresses.

Yet as much as trade drove early Americans across the oceans, it was war that brought American power proper into the Indo-Pacific. For the new country, the Pacific was a region of geopolitical competition with its former colonial master, Great Britain, as well as other European nations who looked askance at the new merchant intruders. American military power, limited and inexperienced as it was, initially was deployed to uphold US neutrality rights in shipping that were threatened by other European maritime powers. The protection of American commerce in the Pacific thus catalyzed the emergence of an official US presence in the region, represented primarily by the US Navy, with only sporadic consular representation for the first third of the nineteenth century. Yet there was little in Washington's policy that initially could be considered a comprehensive or consistent strategy, let alone a truly grand strategy on the part of the young republic. Scattershot American attention overrode sometimes ambitious intentions, and it is not until the middle of the nineteenth century that even the beginnings of a true strategy toward the Indo-Pacific can be discerned. That should not, however, lead us to overlook the fact that the new nation sought to project what maritime power it could into the Pacific decades before a more comprehensive strategy emerged.

It is well known that the first American merchant ship to trade with Asia, the *Empress of China*, sailed for China across the Atlantic Ocean